

Weiner 1962 RG Notes

Weiner, Myron. *The Politics of Scarcity: Public Pressure and Political Response in India*.

Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1962.

1 Main Idea

2 General Notes

- “At the heart of this study is a simple problem. In a free society, there is an increase in the freedom of choice and in the capacity to affect one’s environment – a freedom and a capacity exercised by people who voluntarily associate to influence the course of public policy. Freedom of association, freedom of assembly, a free press, and free speech are the freedoms maintained in a democratic society so that citizens may affect their government. On the other hand, voluntary associations would defeat their own purposes if they were to effectively paralyze government, destroy orderly rule, or threaten to Balkanize the political system.”
- “The nationalists were creating a Leviathan of aspirations” – might be wise to use this phrase a bit more broadly when considering the impact of rapid expansion and development on political outcomes and social cohesion

3 Important Specific Factual Claims

- In early/mid-20th century: “Indian leaders saw their task as that of reducing scarcity, which was more acutely felt at the time of Independence than it had been fifty years before, not necessarily because there was greater poverty in India, but because popular aspirations had expanded much more rapidly than had the society’s ability to fulfill public demands.” Attempted to do so from a top-down approach: reducing scarcity should be the responsibility of the government
- As political groups began to disrupt the new social order and more mainstream attempts to satiate them were unsuccessful, Indian officials largely depended on criminal prosecutions and legal restraint/coercion, including those which specifically restrict aforementioned freedoms of speech and press. (State could arrest individuals in anticipation of a future

public statement)

4 Connections

- Seems to be a bit related to the Huntington argument, except instead of the underlying change being economic development, it is instead the development of freedom: political institutions must be sufficiently strong enough to handle new waves of freedom while still maintaining effective policies and scarcity management.

5 My Critiques

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